

DECO7180

PROBLEM FRAMING REPORT

Design Question:

“How might we support women in Australia returning to office work to address experience gaps after childbearing when childcare duties disproportionately affect their careers?”

Yutika Shindolkar – 49595916

Chuxin Zhang – 48969220

Yanjun Lu – 48121877

Ying Sheng- 49726448

TEAM 4
POCHITA 

Contents

Introduction.....	3
1. A Discussion of Your Data.....	3
1.1 Open-Source Datasets.....	3
1.2 Academic and Industry Research.....	3
1.3 Biases, Assumptions, and Risks	4
2. Defining the Problem Space	4
2.1 Core Problem Space	4
2.2 Scope of Problem Space.....	4
2.3 Variable Factors within the Scope	4
3. Identifying Gaps in Knowledge	5
Conclusion.....	5
References	6

Introduction

Women in Australia are exiting and returning to the workforce during their peak childbearing years, and coming back incurs significant career penalties that can affect them for life. These setbacks are not inevitable, but symptomatic of an issue embedded in how we collectively approach returning mothers - an issue that requires us to address feelings and identities as much as skills. With two open-sourced ABS datasets and literature review we explore this issue.

1. A Discussion of Data

1.1 Open-Source Datasets

Our research was guided by two datasets from Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS). The first, Education and Work, Australia, (May 2025) revealed that while 87.5% of Australian men with a bachelor degree aged 25–44 years worked full-time while caring for children under the age of 15 years, only 47.1% of equivalent women did. However, this gap was not due to women being less qualified than men (there are in fact more women than men who hold a bachelor degree or higher, 2,418,300 vs 1,863,000) and in fact many women are still working part-time (675,800 vs 241,600 men). When women do not have children, the gap is significantly smaller (71.1% vs 77.9%).

Another ABS dataset, Employee Earnings and Hours, (May 2025) revealed the gender pay gap is almost non-existent for workers under the age of 20 (3.3%). But as Australians enter their peak career-building ages of 35–44 years, the gap increases to 14%. Combined, these datasets led us to focus on one inflection point: having children and taking a career-break.

What neither dataset shows are the skills lost, networks left untended, and confidence that slips away while on a career break. That gap between what the data shows and what it cannot explain is the core of our problem space.

1.2 Academic and Industry Research

Bahar et al. (2025) analyse Australian longitudinal and tax records to show that mothers experience a 53% reduction in earnings over their first five years with children, while men experience no such penalty. This phenomenon, known internationally as the “child penalty”, follows a similar pattern in OECD countries: motherhood causes women to experience an immediate and persistent decline in employment and career trajectories (Kleven et al., 2019).

The experience of returning women in Australian workplaces has also been shown to reflect structural barriers — not free choice — created by rigid workplace cultures and uneven distributions of labour at home (Gregory, 2021). This speaks to the broader context in which women are not

simply “choosing” to leave the workforce or work fewer hours. There are structural forces at play that push women out and discourage their return.

Mehta and Joseph (2025) provide qualitative evidence on the psychological barriers women face when returning to work. Through interviews, they document how returning women commonly feel like they have lost confidence, experience imposter syndrome, anxiety, and struggle to reconcile their professional identity with their new role. They highlight *skill obsolescence* - the widening gap between a woman’s existing skills and what the current workplace requires - as a key cause of this struggle. Women who returned to work without updating their skills reported lower job satisfaction, felt unable to assert themselves in the workplace, and were less likely to seek out promotions or positions with more responsibility.

When asked about re-entry specifically, Freeney et al. (2025) found that women experience *identity conflict* between their role as a mother and worker. Women who take enough time away from work that they no longer consider themselves to be ‘in the loop’ must reconcile their professional identity with their new role as a mother who has spent significant time out of the workforce.

Ewald et al. (2025) frame these experiences within the context of Australian workplace culture. They argue that although Australia is well supported legislatively when it comes to parental leave, re-integration into the workforce post-children is still enacted through neoliberal structures. This means that care work is individualised and disconnected from the workplace. Through analysis of WGEA data from industries across NSW, they find return-to-work policies specifically for women (such as coaching and mentorship or skills updating) were the least commonly offered forms of support by employers.

1.3 Biases, Assumptions, and Risks

A key interpretive risk is treating the experience gap as a skills gap alone. While this may be true for women working in rapidly evolving technical fields who need to simply update their knowledge, for many women working in relationship-oriented or management jobs the gap is more about networks, visibility and confidence than raw skills.

2. Defining the Problem Space

2.1 Core Problem Space

The central problem we are investigating is the experience gap that forms during a childbearing-related career break, and the difficulty women face in closing that gap when they return to office work. The gap is not simply a matter of missing months or years on a résumé. During a career break, workplace tools and platforms evolve, industry knowledge moves forward, and professional

networks weaken. She is re-entering an environment that has moved on, and in most cases, without any structured support to help her close the distance.

The experience gap affects three aspects: skill currency (whether a woman's technical and professional skills remain relevant after time away), professional identity (whether she still sees herself as competent and belonging in her field), and career progression (whether the break has cost her opportunities for promotion, mentorship, or higher responsibility that peers who stayed in the workforce have accumulated). These three aspects are closely linked: *a woman who feels her skills are outdated is less likely to advocate for herself in performance reviews, less likely to be seen as promotion-ready by managers, and more likely to accept reduced roles on re-entry.*

2.2 Scope of Problem Space

The focus of this research is women aged 25 to 44 in Australia who are returning to office-based roles following a childbearing-related career break. This age group is where employment and career outcomes drastically vary between men and women. Careers based in office-based work require continuous professional development, workplace visibility, and full-time presence. These expectations do not accommodate a career break, and the gap that forms as a result can be significant upon re-entry.

We exclude blue-collar, trade, and remote work settings because the skill currency dynamics, professional norms, and re-entry structures in those contexts are substantially different and would require separate investigation. We also exclude policy and legislative reforms as a design space as our interest is in what can be done within existing workplace structures to address the experience gap at the individual and team level.

2.3 Variable Factors within the Scope

Several contextual factors shape the conditions under which any design response can work in this space. Women returning to office-based roles are already carrying considerable cognitive and emotional load as part of the transition itself, and any form of support needs to be accessible without adding to that weight. The experience gap is also frequently invisible to both parties. The woman returning may not realise the changes occurred during her absence, and her employer may not recognise the gap as a structural issue, considering it instead as a personal shortcoming. This gap differs across industries, role types, length of break, and access to professional networks.

3. Identifying Gaps in Knowledge

Our research reveals trends in employment outcomes, but does not tell the story of what re-entry is like - What does the experience gap actually feel like? What parts of the gap are most challenging? What kind of support might actually help?

First, there is limited research on skill obsolescence as experienced by returning women in Australian office contexts. Mehta and Joseph (2025) document it as a significant driver of psychological distress and reduced confidence on re-entry, but do not examine which skills become obsolete fastest or how women currently attempt to close the gap.

Second, the relationship between the experience gap and career progression remains unclear. Ewald et al. (2025) note that part-time and flexible arrangements returners rely on are rarely linked to promotional pathways. The breakdown mechanism is contested: Correll et al. (2007) provide experimental evidence that mothers are rated as less competent and committed by recruiters regardless of qualifications, while D'hert et al. (2024) confirm that care-related career breaks directly reduce hiring outcomes. Mehta and Joseph (2025) add that diminished confidence leads women to self-exclude from opportunities. Together, these suggest the barrier operates at multiple levels simultaneously.

Third, although Freeney et al. (2025) acknowledge the professional identity challenge of re-entry, there is limited Australian research exploring how women go about re-establishing that identity. Ely et al. (2011) suggest solutions need to be crafted as identity work in tandem with skills development; a purely skills-based response is unlikely to succeed.

These gaps point to a need for qualitative research with returning women that surfaces the lived specifics of the experience gap rather than relying on aggregate data.

Conclusion

The recurring trend throughout our data set analysis as well as those found in academic circles has been that career penalty of a maternity/paternity leave is real and it's systemic. It's exacerbated by a lack of legitimate support in the workplace. The gap - whether it's skill relevancy, professional identity or career momentum - can't be solved with bootstraps. It needs to be designed out with serious consideration for the functional and emotional experience of re-entry women actually live.

References

- Australian Bureau of Statistics. (2025). *Education and work, Australia, May 2025* (Cat. No. 4235.0). ABS.
- Australian Bureau of Statistics. (2026). *Employee earnings and hours, Australia, May 2025* (Cat. No. 6306.0). ABS.
- Bahar, E., Bradshaw, N., Deutscher, N., & Montaigne, M. (2025). Children and the gender earnings gap: Evidence for Australia. *The Economic Record*, 101(332), 41–75. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-4932.12834>
- Ewald, A., Gilbert, E., Duffy, S., & O'Shea, M. (2025). The re-entry to work after parental leave: Australian workplace supports within a neoliberal framework. *Labour & Industry*, 35(3), 229–256. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10301763.2025.2574173>
- Correll, S. J., Benard, S., & Paik, I. (2007). Getting a job: Is there a motherhood penalty? *American Journal of Sociology*, 112(5), 1297–1338. <https://doi.org/10.1086/511799>
- D'hert, L., Lippens, L., & Baert, S. (2024). *Not a lucky break? Why and when a career hiatus hijacks hiring chances* (IZA Discussion Paper No. 17497). <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5046042>
- Ely, R. J., Ibarra, H., & Kolb, D. M. (2011). Taking gender into account: Theory and design for women's leadership development programs. *Academy of Management Learning & Education*, 10(3), 474–493. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amle.2010.0046>
- Freaney, Y., Werff, L., Greenberg, D., Hayden, T., Costello, V., & Coleman, A. (2025). More than “just a mom”: Identity distancing and reactivation during re-entry transitions. *Gender, Work, and Organization*, 32(2), 610–633. <https://doi.org/10.1111/gwao.13172>
- Gregory, S. K. (2021). Managing labour market re-entry following maternity leave among women in the Australian higher education sector. *Journal of Sociology*, 57(3), 577–594. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1440783320927089>
- Kleven, H., Landais, C., Posch, J., Steinhauer, A., & Zweimüller, J. (2019). Child penalties across countries: Evidence and explanations. *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, 109, 122–126. <https://doi.org/10.1257/pandp.20191078>
- Mehta, A., & Joseph, S. (2025). Assessing the psychological mindset of women during and post career break: Challenges and coping mechanism. *EPRA International Journal of Multidisciplinary Research*. <https://doi.org/10.36713/epra20581>